Placement RPI

natural history Museum

La Rochelle

Museum Guidebook





1 sciences and collections

The 19th century is one of the most auspicious periods in the history of sciences.
It was the time when the zoology gallery opened to the public, who could discover animals exhibited according to Georges Cuvier's classification. Naturalists gathered these animals and they made observations and sketches that you can now find in the cabinet of drawings.
The scholars of this area contributed to scientific expeditions : their discoveries changed the theories we used to believe in, and they gave birth to new scientific disciplines such as oceanography and biogeography which are represented through three rooms : one of them is dedicated to a beautiful collection of tropical shellfish.



Charles X's giraffe

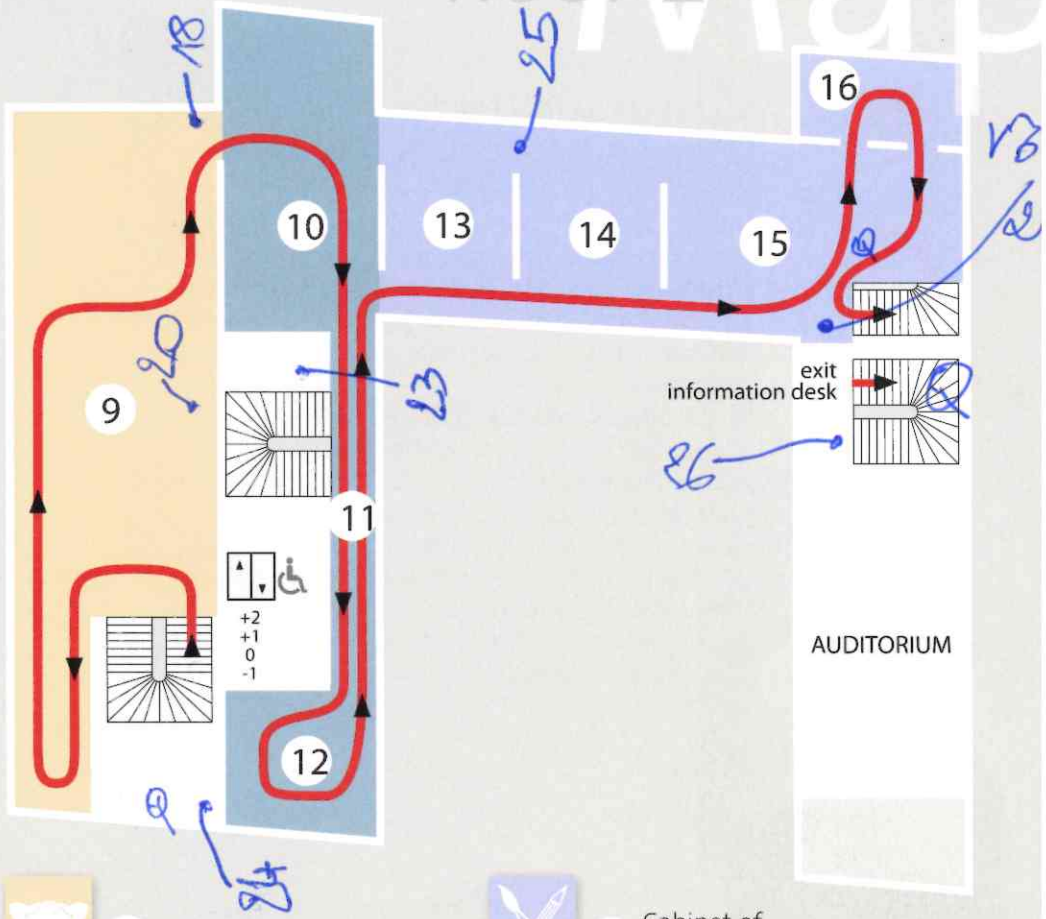


Borda's reflecting circle



Room 10 – Fauna from coast to abyss

floor 1 Map



9 The zoology gallery

10 Fauna from coast to abyss

11 Oceanographic expeditions

12 Molluscs and tropical habitats

13 Cabinet of drawings

14 Naturalists-travellers from Charente

15 The discoveries of naturalists-travellers from Charente

16 The last great scientific expedition

2 from one world to the others

The specimens exhibited have been collected since the beginning of the 19th century by adventurers eager for new discoveries, and then by scientists who desired to understand these new civilizations and people who were so different from them.
Ritual objects and items from everyday life gathered over the years show the genius and innovation of these people, but also their social and cultural practices and their history which has been unknown for a long time. Furthermore, these objects show the evolution of the perception of those who gathered them.
Nowadays, they still help us to be aware of the diversity of societies, and how these civilizations existed.

Sao head



A drum from Mali



Room 22 - Dress ornaments and signs of social hierarchy

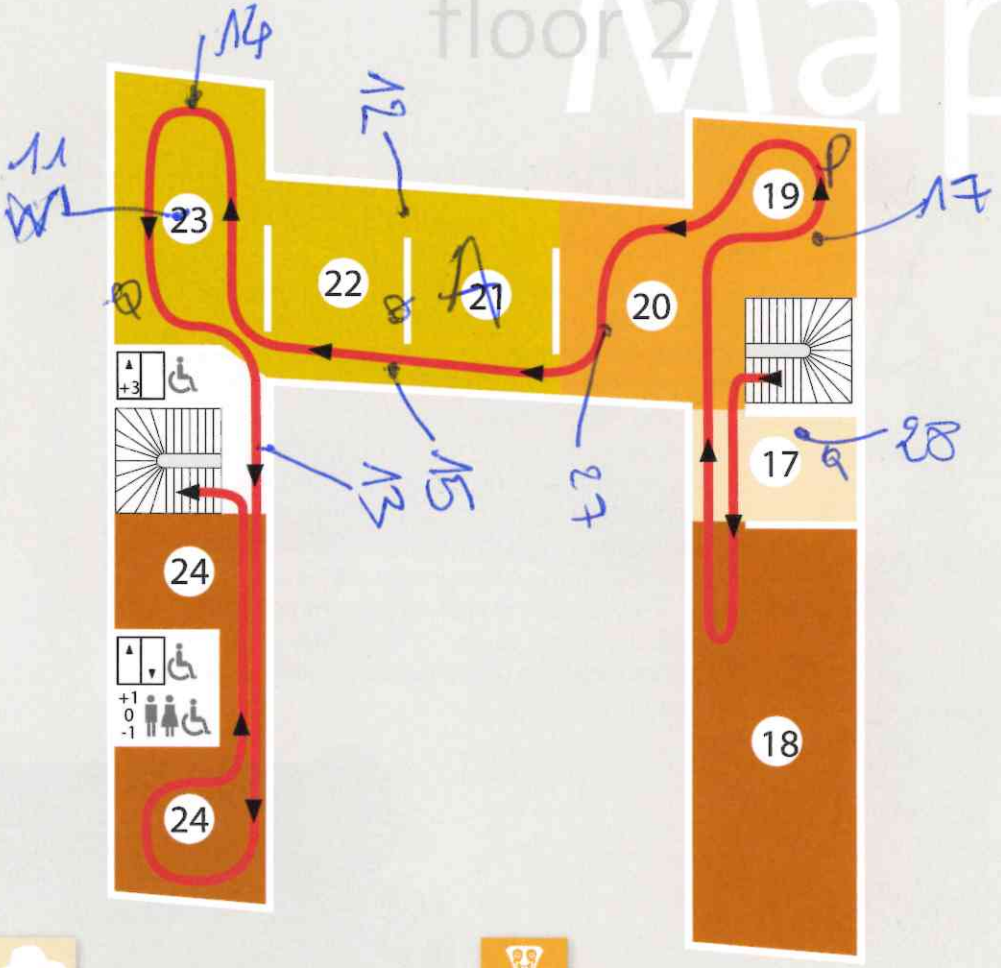




Room 24 - Musical arts

Room 18 – After scientific explorations

floor 2 Map



17 Etienne Loppé : his worldview

18 After scientific explorations

19 The evolution of Western perception

20 African pre & proto history

21 African metallurgy

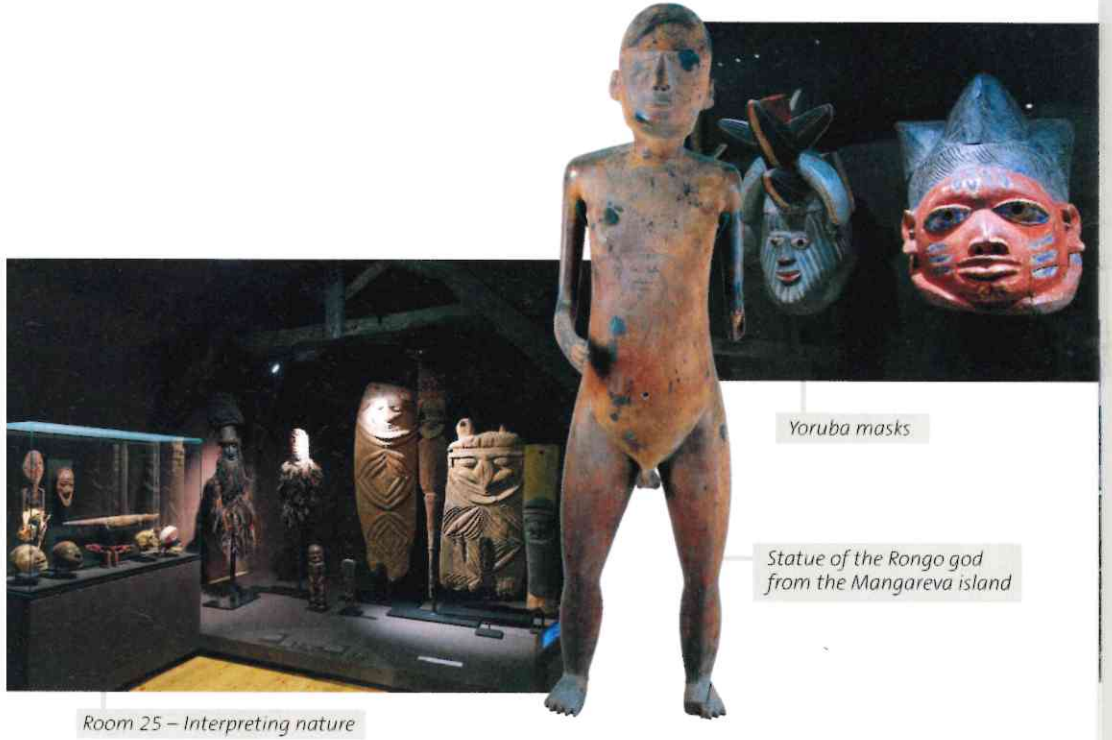
22 Dress ornaments and signs of the social order

23 Non-European decorative Arts

24 Music

3 beyond the sacred : the universal

The observation of the religious rituals allows us to anticipate other conceptions of the world, but science cannot reveal everything and the ethnologist is not always able to decrypt all of the meanings that can be ascribed to a ritual object. Thanks to Etienne Loppé, the Museum exhibits a spectacular Oceanic, African and American collection. This collection shows how the study of human beings progressively prevailed over the fascination for the colonial empire's riches.
Now, the Museum wants to be a multicultural crossroads in the city of La Rochelle, as it has demonstrated with the recent acquisition of new American collections.

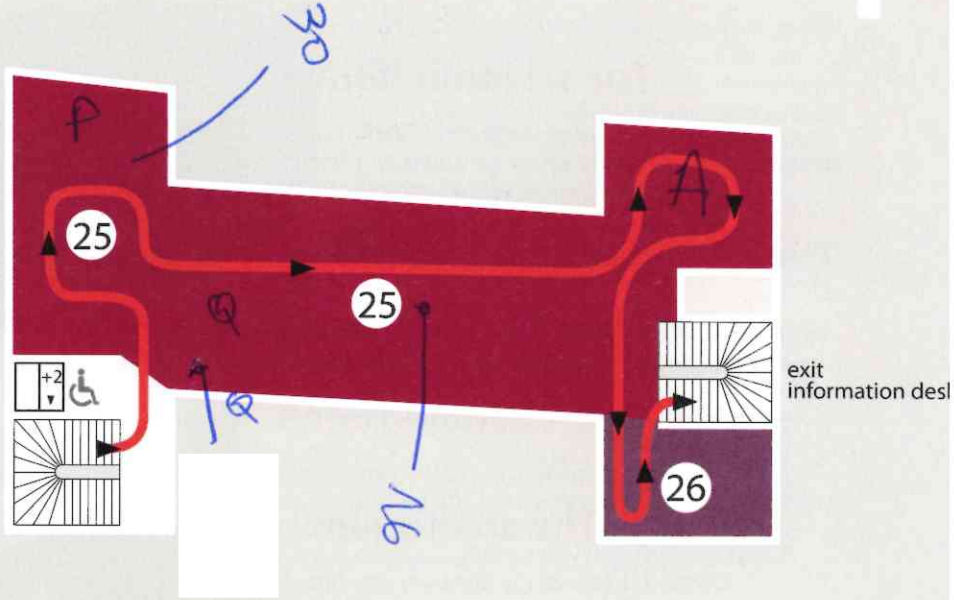


Yoruba masks

Statue of the Rongo god from the Mangareva island

Room 25 – Interpreting nature

Map



25 Interpreting nature

26 The shaman in the Americas : a mediator.